UNIVERSITY OF SOUTH FLORIDA

Stair-Climbing Robotic Dog for Oxygen Therapy Patients

An autonomous quadruped that follows a patient on supplemental oxygen, detects a staircase, and climbs it carrying the tank — freeing both hands for the railing.

Computer Science & Engineering · USF College of Engineering · Team Robodog (Project #6)

MOTIVATION

Patients on long-term oxygen therapy must haul a portable concentrator everywhere — stairs are the highest fall-risk, highest-exertion obstacle in the home.

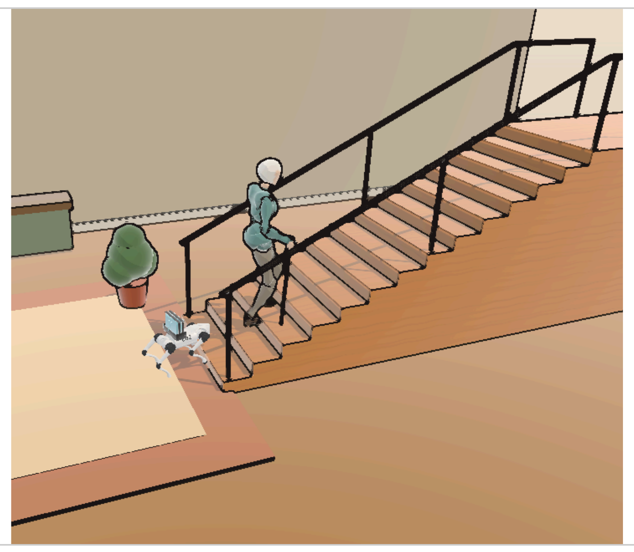

Fig. 1 — The patient still climbs unassisted today; the robot in this Isaac Sim scene is the fix we're building toward.

- Older stair-users show higher stride variability & fall risk **(Startzell 2000; Hausdorff 1997)**.
- Our robot **carries the ~2.2 kg concentrator**, follows autonomously, detects stairs, and climbs — beside the patient.
- Both hands freed for the railing; robot handles the load.
- The goal isn't to replace the patient's independence — it's to remove the one obstacle (the tank) that takes it away.

HARDWARE PLATFORM

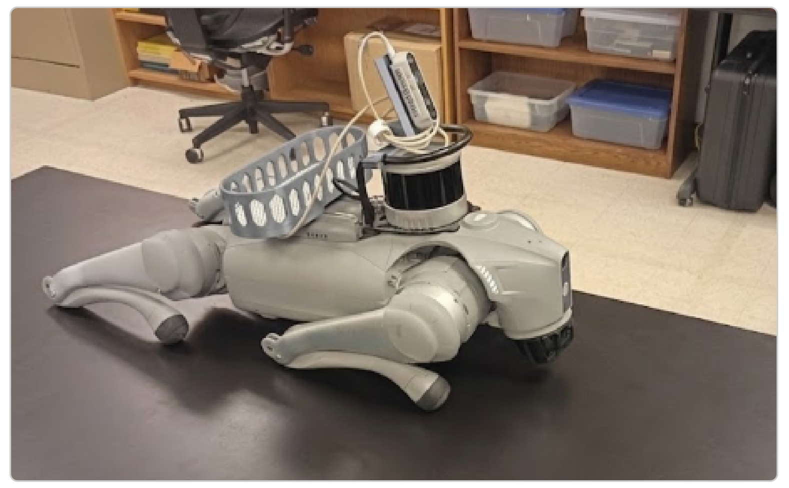

Fig. 2 — Go2 with payload cradle.

Robot: Unitree Go2, 6.9 kg, 12-DOF
Compute: NVIDIA Jetson Orin
Vision: Intel RealSense D435 RGB-D
LiDAR: Hesai XT16
Payload: 2.22 kg mock O_2 + cradle (~32 % of trunk mass)

SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

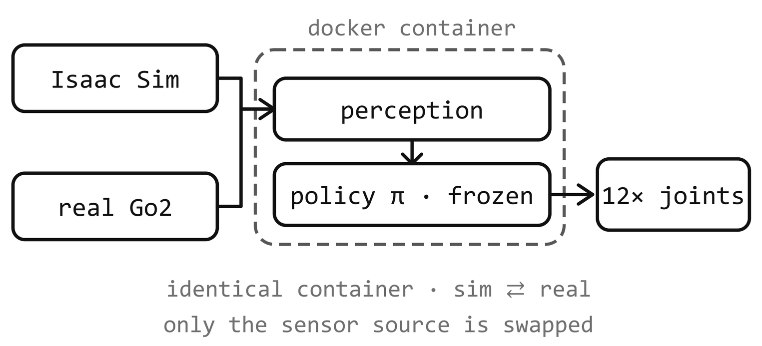

Fig. 3 — One shared codebase runs in NVIDIA Isaac Sim and on the real Go2; only the sensor source is swapped. Perception + control (Jetson / Docker) emit velocity commands; a shared policy library returns 12-DOF joint targets.

WE TRAINED IT TO CLIMB — 6,000 ITERATIONS

A blind reinforcement-learning policy learned to drive the payload upstairs on feel alone.

95.7 — Mean reward at plateau
138 mm — Riser the curriculum settled at
≈100% — Episodes end upright, not a fall

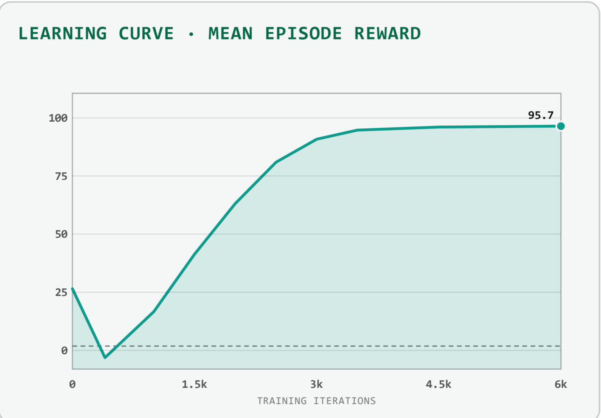

Fig. 4 — Mean episode reward climbs to 95.7 and holds over 6,000 training iterations.

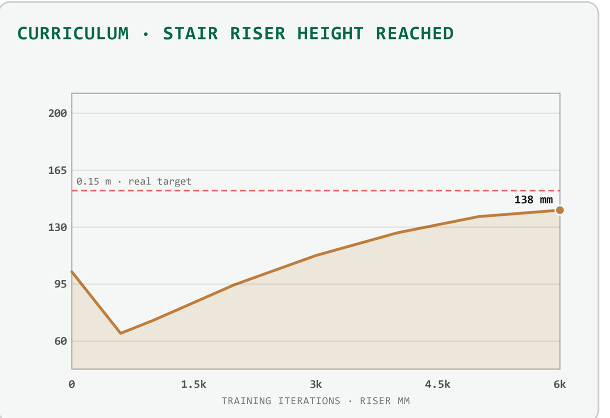

Fig. 5 — Difficulty curriculum settles at a 138 mm riser — right at the real 0.15 m target stair.

Across 6,000 training iterations the mean episode reward climbed to 95.7 and held. A difficulty curriculum pushed the stairs steeper over time, settling at a 138 mm riser — right at the real-world target height. Along the way the policy learned to stop falling — topples collapsed from 92% of episodes to about 3% — and to survive longer, carrying the payload the full climb instead of tipping in the first couple of seconds. The gait it found is cautious, not graceful — it noses down and leans into each riser rather than stepping cleanly — but inside that trained envelope it ends upright almost every time, keeping the payload level.

METHODOLOGY: PERCEIVE → FOLLOW → DETECT → CLIMB

One control loop, running entirely on the robot's onboard Jetson Orin, turns raw camera and LiDAR frames into joint commands in five stages:

1. **Perceive** — RealSense D435 RGB-D + LiDAR feed two parallel vision heads: YOLOv8-Pose (person detection) and YOLO-World (open-vocab stair detection).
2. **Follow** — ByteTrack lock with 3 s occlusion hold. 3-zone PID holds 0.45 m standoff; depth-reactive avoidance routes around furniture.
3. **Detect Stairs** — YOLO-World counts risers; LiDAR depth corroborates (0.6 weight blend). ≥2 risers within 1.6 m triggers handoff. Dual-evidence gate eliminates false positives.
4. **Hand Off** — 50 Hz HandoffController (WALK ⇌ CLIMB → TOP-EGRESS / ABORT) swaps PGTT walker for blind-RL climb policy on motion-stall + riser trigger.
5. **Climb** — Proprioceptive "blind" RL policy drives legs up; at crest the robot walks clear and returns to walk policy.

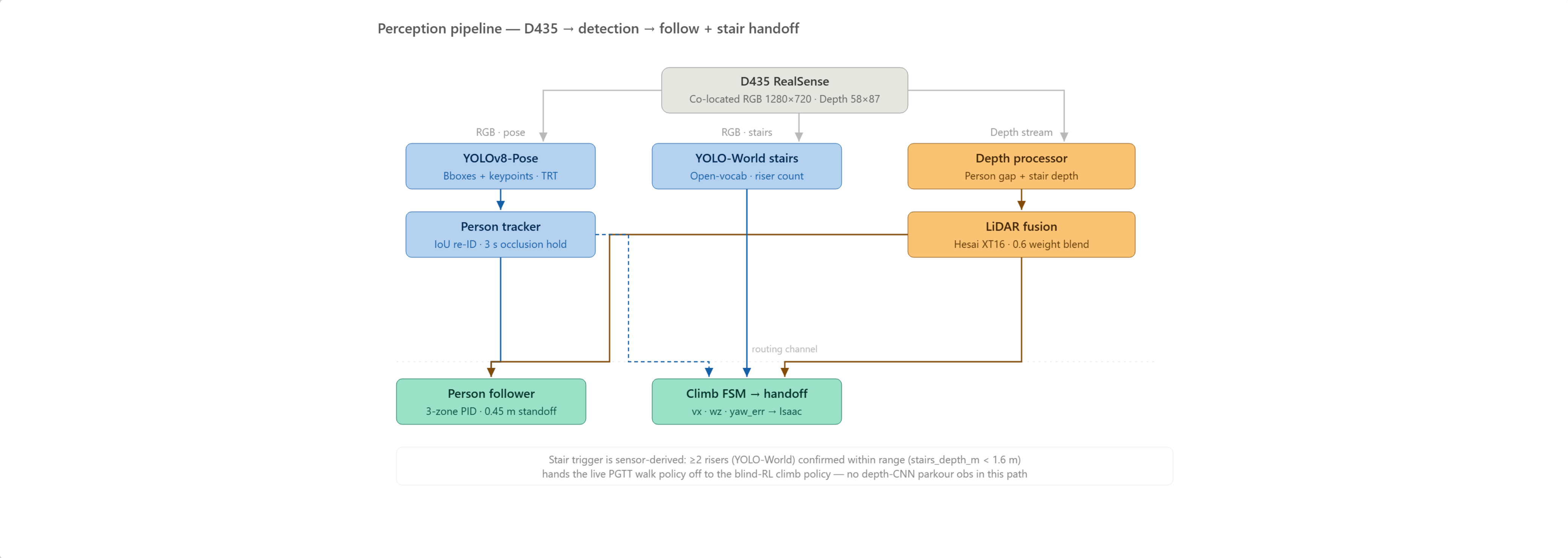

Fig. 6 — Perception pipeline: sensor inputs feed parallel vision heads; outputs merge in the Climb FSM.

The two vision heads run independently and never block each other — losing the person for a moment doesn't stall stair detection, and vice versa.

RESULTS — ISAAC SIM STAIR-HEIGHT SWEEP

4/6 — Full climbs (0.12–0.15 m risers)
0.15 m — ADA-max riser successfully topped
≤31° — Peak body tilt (threshold: 60°)

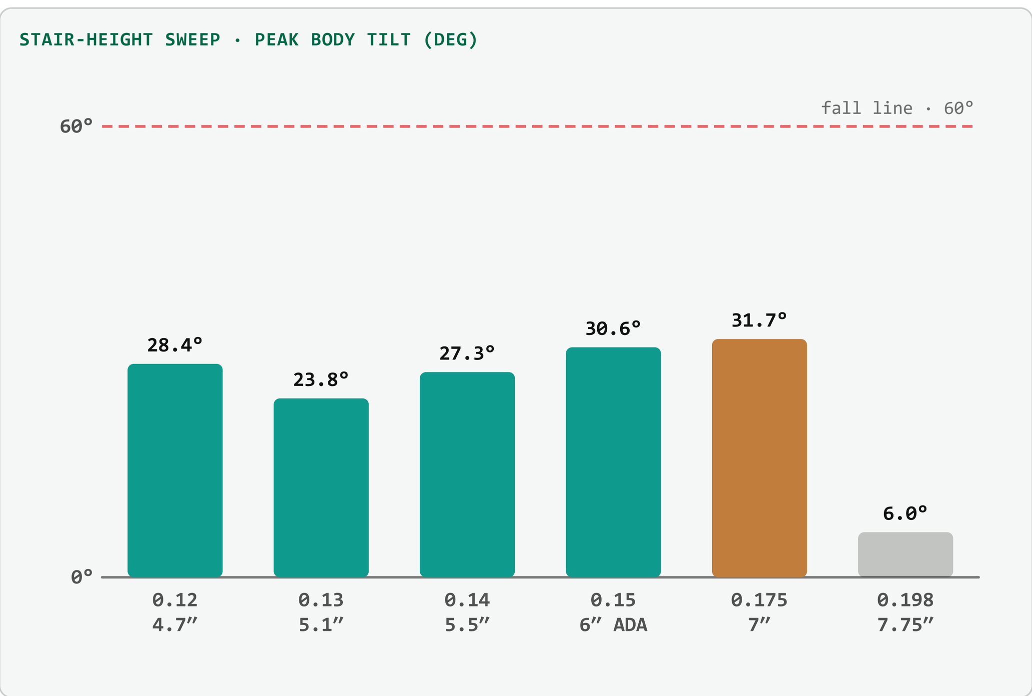

Fig. 7 — Peak body tilt at each riser height, well below the 60° fall line.

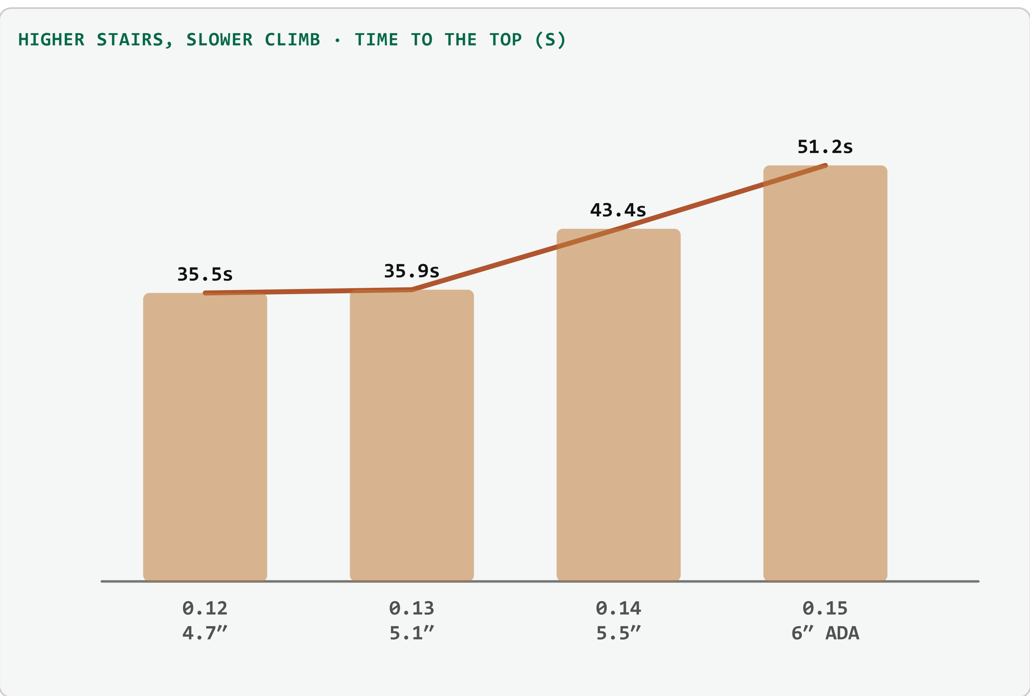

Fig. 8 — Climb time rises from 35.5 s to 51.2 s as the riser grows.

Riser	Steps (/ 14)	Peak Tilt	Outcome
0.120 m (~5″)	**14.0**	28°	✓ Full climb
0.130 m (~5″)	**13.9**	24°	✓ Full climb
0.140 m (~6″)	**13.9**	27°	✓ Full climb
0.150 m (6″ ADA)	**14.0**	31°	✓ Full climb
0.175 m (7″ IBC)	4.4	32°	✗ Partial
0.198 m (7.75″)	0.0	6°	✗ No climb

Robot topped the ADA-maximum (0.15 m) staircase end-to-end in simulation, staying upright throughout (peak tilt ≤31°, well below the 60° fall threshold).

Past code-legal risers the gait rears up against the step instead of driving through it — the same conservative "climb by feel" behavior that keeps it upright at 0.15 m becomes overly cautious once the geometry outruns what the policy was trained on.

WHY THIS MATTERS

About 1.5 million Americans rely on long-term home oxygen therapy, and stairs are consistently the task they fear most — a fall risk that can confine a patient to one floor of their own home. This project builds a sensor-guided quadruped that walks beside the patient, carries the oxygen equipment, and climbs the stairs on its own — so the patient never has to face a staircase alone.

CONTROL STATE MACHINES

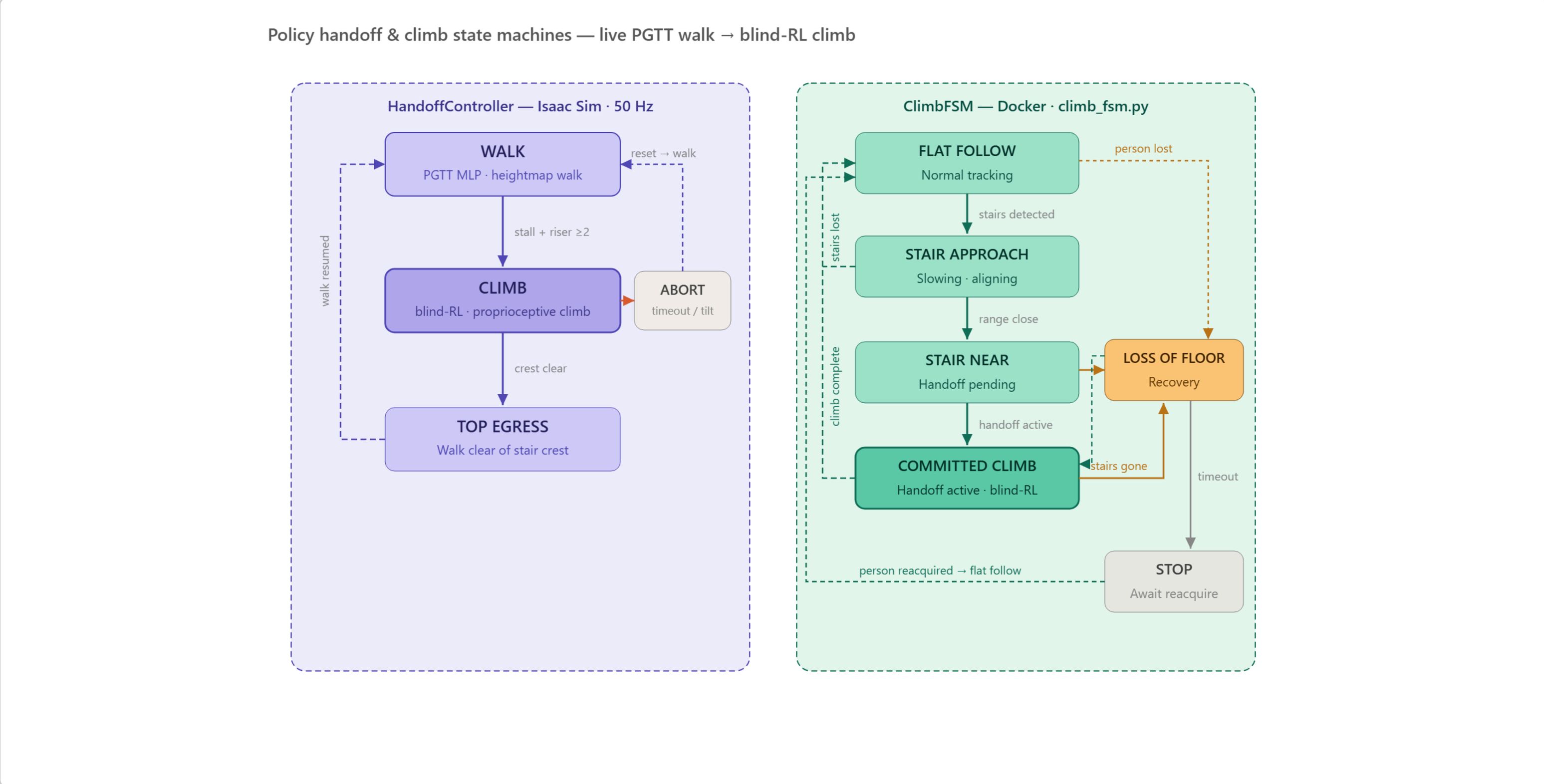

Fig. 9 — HandoffController (Isaac Sim, 50 Hz) and ClimbFSM (Docker) run concurrently via UDP.

Two state machines, one on each side of the UDP link, so a dropped packet or a stalled ClimbFSM can't leave the walker holding a stale climb command.

SIMULATION & TRAINING

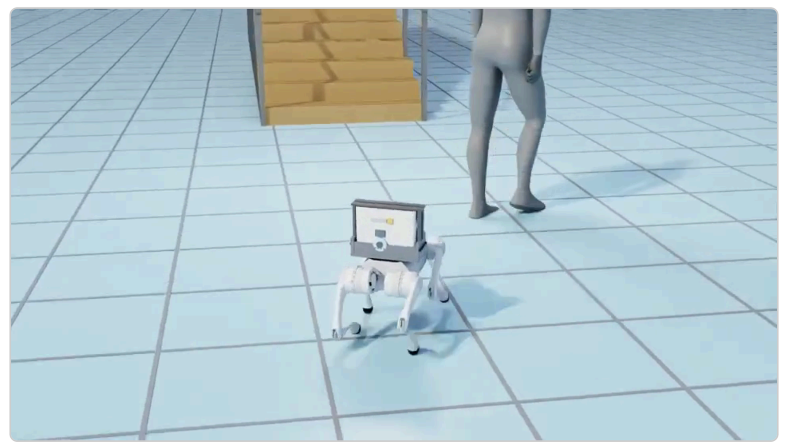

Fig. 10 — Scene view (Isaac Sim rollout): robot trails the patient toward the stairs, carrying the O_2 tank.

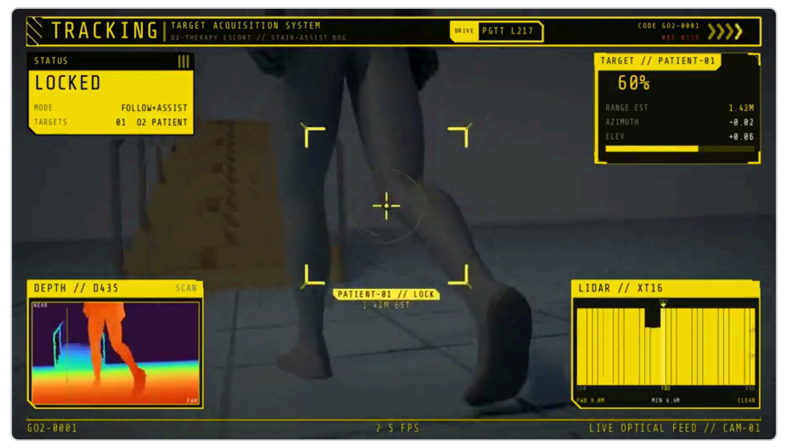

Fig. 11 — Live perception HUD: YOLO-World person lock, D435 depth, and LiDAR range panels.

BLIND-RL CLIMB POLICY

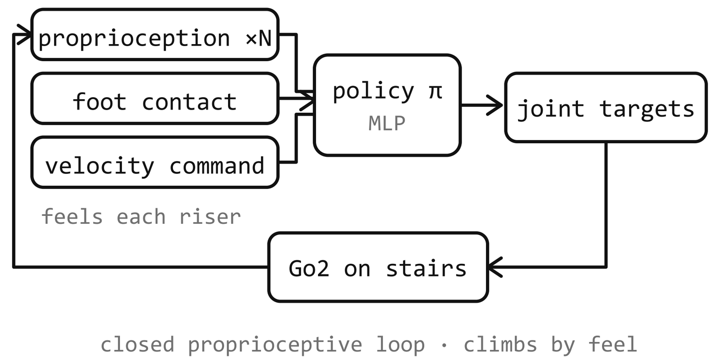

Fig. 12 — Blind-RL policy: no camera, no depth on the stairs — terrain is felt via proprioception + foot contact alone.

Going blind on the stairs was a deliberate choice, not a limitation of the cameras — vision is unreliable right at the robot's feet, where its own body occludes the D435's view of the next riser.

CONCLUSIONS

- End-to-end **follow → detect → hand-off → climb** stack validated in NVIDIA Isaac Sim on a shared sim/real codebase (**401 passing tests**).
- Successfully reaches the top of the **0.15 m (ADA-maximum)** staircase end-to-end in the best demo.
- Peak tilt ≤31° across all successful runs — **well below the 60° fall threshold**.

LIMITATIONS & FUTURE WORK

- **Nose-down gait** — blind-RL climber pitches forward; a gait-posture problem, not a handoff bug.
- **High CoG** — O_2 carrier raises center of gravity; wider stance being explored.
- **Safety grade-gate** — stance locking suppressed mid-climb; min observed clearance 0.209 m vs. 0.55 m target.
- **Hardware climb unproven** — physical Go2 validation is the active next step.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The authors thank **Dr. Kearns** and USF COE faculty for guidance throughout this project. Simulation via **NVIDIA Isaac Sim**. Robot: **Unitree Go2**. Policies adapted from **robot_lab / IsaacLab** and PGTT (arXiv:2510.18348).

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